

*These are notes for when you teach the “Running a Formal Meeting Effectively Class” at Arizona Boys State.*

*The goal of this course is to give a brief but insightful introduction to the delegates about Roberts’ Rules of Order and orient them to what to discuss during the party Caucus. This presentation can become stale very quickly so it is important to keep it entertaining and interactive.*

## **1. The Farse and Problem**

Before the presentation starts understanding why Robert’s Rules of Order exists. Meetings with no rules follow the “Tyranny of the Loudest.” Every assembly of people without rules faces three inevitable failures:

1. The Decibel Democracy: The person with the loudest voice wins, regardless of how stupid their idea is.
2. The Circular Loop: The group talks for 20 minutes but never actually decides anything.
3. The Silent Majority: The smartest people in the room stop participating because they can’t get a word in edgewise.

Once everyone gets settled in divide the room into Federalists and Nationalists. Create a sense of urgency and create a problem to solve, i.e. Tell the delegates to identify the problem work a solution and create a 30 second solution as to what the problem is. They will be “graded” on the response and the teacher will implement the winning decision. This simulation is designed to fail and will last for no more than three minutes (just enough to talk about something but not enough to do anything meaningful):

The Setup –

1. The Topic: Pick something trivial but divisive.
  - a. Example:
    - i. Boys State received \$1B dollars to use, your party is to figure out how to allocate these funds
    - ii. What is the most important issue facing the State of Arizona today and how do you solve this issue?
2. The Rules (or lack thereof): Tell the room: "You have 60 seconds to reach a final decision. There are no rules. You don't need to be called on. Just convince the room."
3. The Trigger: Say "Go," and let it run for exactly no more than three minute.

The Result –

This will hopefully be a disaster, people will yell over each other, groups will form small side-conversations, and someone will probably stand on a chair.

After the allotted time kill the noise (and be strict with timing) and ask three questions:

1. Who is in charge right now? (Answer: Nobody)
2. Was a motion passed or did they come to a decision. (Answer: No, because there wasn't a way to vote)
3. If you had a great counter argument but didn't want to interrupt others, did your voice get heard? (Answer: No)

You can ask other things, like:

1. For the people who did have ideas, can you present them?
  - a. For the group, raise your hand if this resonates with your beliefs
2. Did someone interrupt or dismiss your point of view or opinion?
3. For those that didn't have their opinion heard – do you want to contribute after your ideas were dismissed?

Make this interactive and ask what happened and why it happened. What could be a solution for this?

## 2. The Solution, Robert's Rules of Orders

*Now this presentation will pivot into what Robert's Rules of Order is.*

Frame Robert's Rules of Order not as "boring law," but as the Operating System (OS) for democratic order.

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*"Robert's Rules isn't about being polite. It's about efficiency and protection. It protects the minority's right to be heard and the majority's right to eventually make a damn decision."*

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The “Big Three” Problems Robert's Rules of Order Solves:

| The Problem                    | The Robert's Rules Fix                                           |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| People talking over each other | <b>Obtaining the Floor:</b> You must be recognized by the Chair. |
| Talking about 5 things at once | <b>The Main Motion:</b> Only one piece of business at a time.    |

|                                    |                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Problem</b>                 | <b>The Robert's Rules Fix</b>                                                   |
| <b>The debate going on forever</b> | <b>Calling the Question:</b> A 2/3 vote forces an immediate end to the chatter. |

### 3. A quick guide into what Robert's Rules of Order:

In the handbook or caucus guide, there is a detailed method as to how to what to do when. The whole point of Robert's Rules is to keep order, remain efficient, and maintain respect for your fellow meeting members while disagreeing in a civil manner. All Boys State meetings should be run using Robert's Rules of Order, especially during all offices operating. The following is a condensed form of the meeting structure:

- 1) Call to order, roll call, and agreeing on the previous meeting minutes
- 2) Officer Reports and old business
- 3) New Business
- 4) Announcements and adjournment

Call to order is when the chairman starts the meeting

Roll call is a way to accurately count everyone in the audience – for smaller meetings this can be skipped.

Prior meeting approvals: If there was a previous meeting the first agenda will be to agree on the previous meeting. The secretary will walk through what was agreed on last meeting, discussed, etc. Furthermore, this serves as a starting point for the agenda for today.

Officer Reports & Special Committee Reports: The officers will need to go through any outstanding items that they would want to speak to or need to speak to before the formal meeting begins. These reports from a special committee or an officer will serve as the first agenda item for old business.

Old Business: These are other outstanding items (old agenda items) that need to be addressed.

New Business: These are new items that either arise from what is discussed from old business or unrelated new items. One of these items is to agree on the agenda for next meeting.

Announcements & Adjournment: Ends the meeting

### 4. Membership and choices

A meeting is comprised of a chairman, a vice-chairman, and a secretary. The chairman is in charge of running the meeting, the vice-chair assists the chairman and the secretary, and the secretary is in charge of documenting the meeting. There may be special privileges granted to certain members

to speak on behalf of the group that they represent to maximize efficiency (in a city chairman on behalf of their city) – however this does not supersede the right of the individual members.

There are several methods to vote: voice, rising, ballot, unanimous consent, roll call, etc. Each type of meeting will have a specific purpose attached. Below are the pros and cons of each voting method:

| <b>Voting Method</b>                  | <b>Pros</b>                                                                        | <b>Cons</b>                                                             | <b>Best Used For...</b>                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Voice Vote</b>                     | High speed; very efficient for routine business.                                   | Hard to judge close margins; "loud" voices can skew perception.         | Non-controversial motions and simple amendments.                                             |
| <b>Rising Vote</b> (or Show of Hands) | More accurate than voice; provides a clear visual of support.                      | Not anonymous; manual counting takes time in large rooms.               | Verifying a close voice vote or motions requiring a 2/3 majority.                            |
| <b>Ballot Vote</b>                    | <b>Full anonymity</b> ; protects members from peer pressure or retaliation.        | Slowest method; requires preparation, collection, and counting.         | Elections, disciplinary matters, and sensitive "hot-button" issues.                          |
| <b>Unanimous Consent</b>              | The fastest possible method; bypasses formal voting procedures.                    | A single objection halts the process and forces a formal vote.          | Approving minutes, adjourning, or minor procedural changes.                                  |
| <b>Roll Call Vote</b>                 | Maximum accountability; creates a permanent public record of each member's stance. | Extremely time-consuming; can be used to intimidate or "target" voters. | Government bodies and organizations where representatives are accountable to a constituency. |

There are a ton of resources available to you in the caucus guide that covers rules of order. So, we'll highlight the main ways to communicate in Robert's Rules of Order.

All items in Roberts Rules are handled with motions, you are debating, discussing, amending motions, not one another. Here are the following items:

**You want to bring up a new idea before the group.**

After recognition by the president of the board, present your motion. A second is required for the motion to go to the floor for discussion, or consideration.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to \_\_\_\_"*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*
- Chairman: *"We will move to \_\_\_\_, is there discussion?"*

**You want to change some of the wording in a motion under discussion.**

After recognition by the chairman of the board, move to amend by adding words, striking words or striking and inserting words.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to amend the current motion by [adding, striking, and/or inserting] \_\_\_\_ due to discussion on the floor"*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*
- Chairman: *"Is there discussion?"*

**You like the idea of a motion being discussed, but you need to reword it beyond simple word changes.**

Move to substitute your motion for the original motion. If it is seconded, discussion will continue on both motions and eventually the body will vote on which motion they prefer.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to substitute the current motion by \_\_\_\_."*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*
- Chairman: *"Is there discussion?"*

**You want more study and/or investigation given to the idea being discussed.**

Move to refer to a committee. Try to be specific as to the charge to the committee.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to refer to committee \_\_\_\_."*

- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*
- Chairman: *"Is there discussion?"*

**You want more time personally to study the proposal being discussed.**

Move to postpone to a definite time or date.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to postpone the current motion to \_\_\_\_."*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*
- Chairman: *"Is there discussion?"*

**You are tired of the current discussion.**

Move to limit debate to a set period of time or to a set number of speakers. Requires a 2/3<sup>rd</sup>s vote and is not subject to discussion.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to limit debate to \_\_\_\_ [seconds/minutes/hours]."*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*

**You have heard enough discussion.**

Move to close the debate. Also referred to as calling the question. This cuts off discussion and brings the assembly to a vote on the pending question only. Requires a 2/3<sup>rd</sup>s vote.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move to call the previous question"*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*

**You want to postpone the motion until some later time.**

Move to table the motion. The motion may be taken from the table after 1 item of business has been conducted. If the motion is not taken from the table by the end of the next meeting, it is dead. To kill a motion at the time it is tabled requires a 2/3<sup>rd</sup>s vote. A majority is required to table a motion without killing it.

**You believe the discussion has drifted away from the agenda and want to bring it back.**

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I call for orders of the day."*
- Chairman: *"The current agenda item is \_\_\_\_."*

### **You want to take a short break.**

Move to recess for a set period of time.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move recess for \_\_\_\_minutes/hours "*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*
- Other member(s): *"Second"*

### **You want to end the meeting.**

Move to adjourn.

- Member: *"Mr. Chairman, I move adjourn the meeting"*
- Chairman: *"Is there a second?"*

Other member(s): *"Second"*

Finally, there are certain things one can do to interrupt the speaker:

- to get information about business – point of information to get information about rules– parliamentary inquiry
- if you can't hear, safety reasons, comfort, etc. –question of privilege
- if you see a breach of the rules –point of order
- if you disagree with the president of the board's ruling –appeal
- if you disagree with a call for Unanimous Consent –object
- Unsure if the president of the board announced the results correctly division

Know that if you abuse these privileges, you can get kicked out or be silenced by either a call to order, a recess, or a motion to remove.

## **5. The Caucus**

Certain organizations like executive boards of companies, the United States federal / state government, and non-profit organizations use Robert's Rules of Order to run their meetings. Getting exposed to this sooner rather than later can assist you in small civil matters like dealing with your HOA or voicing your opinion to your city's council.

Robert's Rules allows for fair and efficient meetings, ensuring that all members have an equal opportunity to participate while maintaining order and decorum. Individuals at Boys State will have many opportunities to disagree with each other's ideas during the caucus. Robert's Rules allows individuals to discuss ideas without devolving to arguing with one another.

The point of these caucuses is to both propose a platform for which the government entity can run on and begin hearing who is running on what.

The city is dealing with smaller (more important) local issues – zoning, public transportation, housing, city parks, city taxation, etc.

The county is dealing with county level issues and inter-city issues – public safety and enforcement (county jail reform, search and rescue/emergency services), infrastructure and land use (zoning, digitalization, waste management), public health and social services, and finance (property tax, economic incentives, etc).

The state is dealing with wider issues and inter county issues – like education policy and funding, criminal justice and reform, digital frontier, and energy.

Before each of these meetings come with ideas as to what you want to discuss.

## **6. The final simulation**

Spend the remaining time running the simulation from the beginning and chose the three people who discussed to be the chairman, vice-chair, and secretary:

The Setup –

1. The Topic: Pick something trivial but divisive.
  - a. Example:
    - i. Boys State received \$1B dollars to use, your party is to figure out how to allocate these funds
    - ii. What is the most important issue facing the State of Arizona today and how do you solve this issue?

Walk around and help people form a miniature caucus to resolve the issues here.